Before and After Writing Examples

Scientific Communication: Writing, Slide Design and Presentation Skills

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Worked example: a results paragraph

All data are fictional. The original paragraph is short and confident, and it overstates.

Before

> It is a well-known fact that post-discharge follow-up is of great importance. The implementation of nurse telephone calls in our hospitals led to a highly significant reduction in readmissions of 32% ($p<0.05$), which proves that the intervention works and should be rolled out everywhere. There was no effect on emergency visits.

After

> We examined whether a nurse telephone call within 72 hours of discharge was associated with fewer unplanned readmissions. Of 850 adults discharged from medical wards at two hospitals, 60 of 412 who received a call (14.6%) and 94 of 438 who did not (21.5%) were readmitted within 30 days, a difference of 6.9 percentage points (95% CI 1.8 to 12.0). Patients who received calls were less often at high risk at discharge (29% v 45%). Within risk strata the combined difference was 4.3 percentage points (95% CI 9.4 lower to 0.8 higher). Because calls were not randomised, these results do not show that the calls caused the difference. Emergency visits without admission were 9.7% and 10.7%, but the interval (5.1 lower to 3.0 higher per 100) is too wide to rule out a useful benefit or a small harm.

Table: what changed and why.

What changed	Why
Removed the opening claim	"Well-known" and "great importance" give the reader nothing to check.
Replaced the verb	"Led to" and "proves" claim cause. The calls were not randomised, so the question is now stated as an association.
Added counts and denominators	32% sounds large and hides the base. 60 of 412 and 94 of 438 let a reader check it.
Reported the absolute difference and its interval	A risk difference with a 95% CI shows size and precision. "Highly significant" shows neither.
Exposed the confounder	High-risk patients were harder to reach. Readers need this to judge the crude result.
Moved the recommendation out	A results paragraph reports. The recommendation belongs in the conclusion, where it can be argued.
Rewrote "no effect"	A wide interval around a small difference means the data cannot tell. It does not show the calls had no effect.

One finding in four forms

The same result, rewritten for four uses. Words change between versions. The size, the population, the design and the uncertainty do not.

Form	Text
Paragraph	The 'after' paragraph above.
Abstract passage	Results: Of 850 patients, 60/412 (14.6%) with a call and 94/438 (21.5%) without were readmitted within 30 days (risk difference 6.9 percentage points lower, 95% CI 1.8 to 12.0 lower). After stratifying by discharge risk the difference was 4.3 points lower (95% CI 9.4 lower to 0.8 higher). Conclusions: Follow-up calls were associated with fewer readmissions, but much of the gap may reflect lower risk among patients reached. A randomised evaluation is needed.
Slide headline	Patients who got a call had fewer readmissions, but the gap narrowed after accounting for risk
Spoken explanation	For every hundred patients, those who got a call had about seven fewer readmissions. But the nurses reached healthier patients more easily. When we compare like with like, the gap is about four per hundred, and the data fit anything from nine fewer to one more. So this is a promising signal. It is not yet proof.

Sentence repairs

Eight common problems, with an explanation of each repair.

Problem	Before	After	Why
Vague	Readmissions were considerably lower in the call group.	Readmissions were 6.9 percentage points lower in the call group (14.6% v 21.5%).	Name the size.
Wordy	Due to the fact that a large number of patients could not be contacted, it was not possible to make calls to all of them.	Nurses could not call every patient, so 438 received no call.	Fewer words, same fact, and a real verb.
Jargon	Post-discharge telephonic engagement modalities were operationalised by nursing staff.	Nurses telephoned patients after discharge.	Keep technical terms when they carry meaning. These do not.
Result or interpretation	The calls worked, with 14.6% readmitted.	14.6% of patients who received a call were readmitted. (Result.) This may reflect the call, or that healthier patients were easier to reach. (Interpretation.)	Mark where the data end and your reading begins.
Denominator	95 readmissions at Hospital A against 59 at Hospital B shows that A performs worse.	Hospital A readmitted 95 of 540 patients (17.6%) and Hospital B 59 of 310 (19.0%).	Counts without denominators reverse the picture here.
Uncertainty	The calls reduce readmissions by 4.3 percentage points.	After stratifying by discharge risk, the estimate was 4.3 points lower (95% CI 9.4 lower to 0.8 higher).	A single number hides how much the data allow.

Problem	Before	After	Why
Causal language	Calls prevent readmissions.	Patients who received calls were less often readmitted. We cannot say from this design whether the calls caused this.	Match the verb to the design.
Non-significant	The coating had no effect on temperature (p>0.05).	Coated rooms were 1.2 °C cooler on average, but the 95% CI ran from 2.5 °C cooler to 0.1 °C warmer.	"Not significant" is not "no effect".